

Donate



Breaking the silence on World Diabetes Day, hearing from people living with diabetes

14 November 2023 | Reading time: 4 min (1057 words)

People with diabetes continue to carry a heavy burden of stigma and discrimination around the world. On World Diabetes Day, we read about the experiences of 6

individuals who shed light on the challenges they've faced following their diagnosis.

Arvind, hailing from India and who lives with type 2 diabetes, discusses the pervasive societal stigma surrounding relationships and marriage for people with diabetes, while also sharing his experiences of workplace discrimination.

Heather, who has been living with type 2 diabetes for over 10 years, talks about the pricey diabetes medication in Zimbabwe and recounts the relentless judgement and the toll it has taken on her well-being.

Rania's journey unfolds as she grapples with the judgement and misconceptions of friends during her school days following her diagnosis of type 1 diabetes, ultimately finding strength through the support of her family and health care team in Algeria.

Nikhita, who also lives with type 1 diabetes, emphasizes the importance of collective efforts in raising awareness and humanizing diabetes through lived experience based on her experience in the United States of America.

Karmila's experience with type 2 diabetes in Indonesia is a poignant reminder of the financial barriers many face in accessing necessary diabetes screenings and care,

highlighting the urgent need for affordable health care.

Andrés, whose experience living with type 2 diabetes in Spain, speaks to the vital importance of ensuring reliable access to blood glucose monitoring equipment, dispelling the misconception that providing supplies is expensive compared to managing complications.

These stories collectively underscore the need for compassion, awareness, and change to improve the lives of those living with diabetes.

Arvind, living with type 2 diabetes from India



"Diabetes still is looked down upon as social stigma. Especially **when it comes to relationship matters, people hesitate to consider people living with diabetes.** These rejections are quite common. I have faced this stigma myself until I found my soulmate in someone

who lives with type 1 diabetes!

I have faced lot of discrimination at work. Though this discrimination is not direct or obvious, I could still feel it. The corporate management has this idea that being diabetic I can't handle workloads and stress like other "normal" people and treat me differently.

Educating people with right information can help a lot to reduce this stigma or discrimination."

Heather, living with type 2 diabetes from Zimbabwe



"The greatest barrier to accessing medication in my country is cost. It affects the majority of people living with the condition, who end up going without medication for long periods and/or rationing their supplies particularly insulin. This leads to worse treatment outcomes and premature deaths.

Having lived with type 2 diabetes for the past 10 years, I am no stranger to diabetes-related stigma and discrimination. **I have been subject to both blatant and subtle judgement, including negative looks and derogatory remarks about what I should have done**

or not done in order to prevent type 2 diabetes. The feeling of being constantly judged has been quite overwhelming for me, bringing out feelings of embarrassment, self-blame, guilt, psychological distress and a generally reduced quality of life for me.

Ending diabetes stigma starts with education and raising awareness. Governments, civil society and international health organizations must be responsible for raising awareness in communities to enhance understanding on the condition. All this will go a long way in the creation of a more compassionate and respectful world for people with diabetes."

Rania, living with type 1 diabetes from Algeria



"After my diagnosis, when I returned to school, my friends started telling me that I couldn't eat candies or drink juice. So, I would eat it in front of them to prove that I could eat whatever I want. When I got back home, I would inject more insulin to have

hypoglycaemia and then eat again. Also, back then, I thought having low blood sugar was better than high

blood sugar. As a result of this, I gained weight and people started telling me that I looked overweight and ugly due to the weight I had gained. It got to the point where I hated seeing myself in the mirror. However, thanks to my parents and my doctor, I was able to overcome this."

Nikhita, living with type 1 diabetes from the United States of America



"Diabetes affects every aspect of your life, so it is so important that your community is on board. Our communities are some of our biggest strengths and can offer meaningful support to raise awareness about diabetes.

Lived experience is so important when it comes to raising awareness about diabetes. Hearing someone's story sticks with you – it humanizes the condition, making it more than just statistics and buzz words, and shows you that diabetes can affect anyone. People who

have lived through the challenges of managing diabetes and its complications can inspire their peers to adopt healthier lifestyles and preventative measures."

Karmila, living with type 2 diabetes from Indonesia



"I don't attend regular screening for complications related to my diabetes. I know that's not ideal, but the cost to do that is very pricey and no insurance would cover a medical check-up. I realized without screening I put myself at risk. I might find out I already have complication to such a degree when my body showed some

symptoms.

I have experienced several complications related to diabetes. Last year, I was diagnosed with hypertension, dyslipidaemia, and angina pectoris aside from my depression. I was diagnosed with diabetes during a recruitment process. The medical check-up showed my

glucose level was out of range, so at that time I did not get the job. It's one of the triggers of my depression because it made me feel like I have no future.

By educating people about diabetes, it would increase understanding towards people who live with diabetes. When the understanding level increases, stigma decreases."

Andrés, living with type 2 diabetes from Spain



"I've had problems for many years getting equipment to check blood glucose levels, and many people with type 2 diabetes have unreliable access to supplies or no access at all, and you can't do anything about blood glucose levels if you can't check them. Doctors know that long-term hyperglycaemia has serious

consequences. The excuse we always hear is that it's very expensive to give us supplies, but it's actually more expensive when we have complications."

Intention to action series: people power. Perspectives from individuals with lived experience of noncommunicable diseases, mental health conditions and neurological conditions

Meaningful engagement of people with lived experience of noncommunicable diseases and mental health and neurological conditions

Knowledge Action Portal on NCDs: Meaningful engagement of people with lived experience